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Israeli-Palestinian Conflict

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IDSS 4900-01 Interdisciplinary Studies Capstone

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Abstract

The Israeli-Palestinian conflict is a complex enduring challenge. This research will take an interdisciplinary approach integrating history, political science, and sociology, perspectives to analyze the conflict. By examining the interplay of historical narratives, political decisions, and cultural identities, the study aims to provide an understanding of the conflicts root cause and perpetuating dynamics. The research will explore the best innovative pathways to take to bring peace to the Middle East. The goal is to introduce a three-state solution.

Israeli -Palestinian Conflict

Introduction

According to (Salvato,2006) Around 1400 B.C., Moses led Hebrew slaves to Palestine, the "promised land." After the Romans destroyed Jerusalem in 70 A.D., the Jewish state ended, and Jews were, dispersed. In the early 20th century, driven by Zionism, Jews returned to British-controlled Palestine, sparking a modern conflict with Palestinians. (Salvato,2006)

During WWI, the Balfour Declaration favored a Jewish national home. Palestine was, divided with Jordan in the east ruled by Abdullah ibn Hussein. The western half, contested by Palestinian Arabs and Zionist Jews, was handed to the UN. The UN partitioned it into two states: one for Jews in the Negev Desert and coastal plain, and the other for Palestinian Arabs in the West Bank, Gaza, Jaffa, and Galilee. Jerusalem remained under U.N. control. Zionists accepted the plan; Palestinian Arabs and neighboring states rejected it. (Salvato,2006)

On May 15, 1948, with support from Jordan, Egypt, Syria, Lebanon, Saudi Arabia, and Iraq, Palestine initiated a war to thwart Jewish independence and gain control of Western Palestine. The outcome saw Zionists occupying land meant for Palestinians, Jordan annexing the West Bank, and Egypt taking charge of Gaza. The struggle for Jerusalem ensued, with Israeli forces securing control over West Jerusalem, subsequently established as the capital of Israel. Around 725,000 Arabs became Palestinian refugees, fleeing to neighboring Arab countries. (Salvato,2006)

In regions annexed by Jordan or Egypt, Palestinians were, not permitted to establish independent governments. Nevertheless, Arab states granted Palestinian resistance groups

the opportunity to organize. In 1964, the Arab League formed the Palestine Liberation Organization (PLO), allowing them to launch raids against Israel from their territories. The PLO aimed to establish an independent Palestinian state through armed struggle. Harsh living conditions and being, treated, as second-class citizens prompted many, Palestinians in Egypt, Jordan, Lebanon, and Syria to join in guerilla movements. (Salvato,2006)

Starting in 1987, Palestinians in Israeli-occupied areas initiated an Intifada ("uprising") against Jewish settlers in the West Bank and Gaza Strip. Simultaneously, groups like Hamas emerged, advocating violence, encouraging attacks on Israelis and Israeli targets, and pushing for an Islamic state in both Israel and the occupied territories. Consequently, Israel imposed restrictions on Palestinians' entry. Ongoing acts of terror led to heightened constraints, with the Israel Defense Force presence escalating in response to each wave of violence. The evolving defensive measures created a challenging situation for both Palestinians and Israelis. Hamas was, formed, with the explicit goal of destroying Israel. Rooted in Islam, it emphasizes total submission to God's will, adherence to Islamic law, and hostility towards non-believers. (Salvato,2006)

In 2000, Palestinian leader Yasser Arafat rejected an offer for a Palestinian state in areas of Israeli withdrawal, proposed by Israeli Prime Minister Ehud Barak and brokered by the Clinton administration. This rejection led to a second Intifada against Israel, and substantive negotiations have been absent since. Despite hopes for progress under Arafat's successor, Mahmoud Abbas, he has struggled to control Palestinian militants. Currently, his party has lost control of the Palestinian parliament to the radical, militant, and terrorism-supporting Hamas in the West Bank and Gaza Strip.

Problem Statement

The Israeli -Palestinian conflict stands as a profoundly complex and enduring challenge that transcends conventional disciplinary boundaries. This research will employ an interdisciplinary approach, integrating historical, political, and sociocultural perspective to analyze the conflict's multifaceted nature. The academic disciplines that will be used include History, Political Science, and Sociology.

Through an interdisciplinary lens, the research endeavors to explore innovative pathways for conflict resolution, addressing the intricate intersections of history, politics, and culture. The goal is to contribute to a deeper, more holistic comprehension of the conflict and to propose meaningful strategies that could pave for lasting peace in the Middle East.

Rationale

Providing an interdisciplinary approach, integrating insights from history, political science, and sociology, will highlight the multifaceted aspects of the Israeli - Palestinian conflict that cannot be fully, grasped through the lens of a single discipline. There needs to be a sustainable resolution to alleviate the suffering of the innocent people.

Justification for using an interdisciplinary approach.

"The Interdisciplinary approach critically analyzes the relevant disciplinary insights (i.e.., what experts have written) and attempts to create common ground among them in order to produce a more comprehensive understanding or propose a holistic solution." (Repko 2017) With system thinking it breaks down a problem into parts to

reveal internal and external influences then figures out how these parts relate to the problem as a whole and identify which parts different discipline address.

Academic Disciplines

The three most relevant disciplines used to address the Israeli-Palestinian conflict are history, political science, and sociology.

History is the branch of knowledge dealing with past events, a continuous, systematic narrative of past events as relating to a particular people, country, period, person, etc., usually written as a chronological account;

Political Science is highly relevant in addressing the Israeli-Palestinian conflict as it offers a systematic study of political structures, power dynamics, and international relations.

Sociology is a relevant discipline in addressing the Israeli-Palestinian conflict as it offers valuable insights into the societal and cultural dimensions that shape the dynamics of the conflict.

Literature Review

History

History refers to the study, knowledge, interpretation, and recording of the past in a meaningful way. As an academic discipline history is conducted, by historians, individuals who take the time to research, interpret, and put past events into context in a recorded fashion.

When Nasser suffered a fatal heart attack, and was, replaced by Anwar-Sadat, who eventually kicked the Soviet military out of Egypt, established new contacts with the United States, and, after losing another war with Israel in 1973, signed a momentous peace treaty with Israel in1979. (Dine,2022).

(Khaled,2023) who was an advisor to President Yasser Arafat, at Camp David 2000 stated in his article, as Palestinians, we have not effectively conveyed our narrative since the Balfour Declaration and the British Mandate. During this period, our political rights, including the right to self-determination, were denied.

(Weintraub, & Tal, 2023) stated, Zionist historiography, influenced by progress and European nationalism, presents a unified three-period narrative. It starts with the ancient biblical era when the Jewish people established sovereignty in the Land of Israel. Then follows a two-millennia exile, considered the root cause of Jewish suffering. The third phase, the Zionist era, envisions the return to their land and the revival of sovereignty as the sole remedy for afflictions and the path to fulfilling potential (Myers, 1995) (Avineri, 2017)

(Awad, 2021) stated the Islamic Resistance Movement (Harakat al - Muqāwama al-Islamiyah), more commonly by the acronym known as Hamas, officially launched its struggle against Zionism on the eve of the First Intifada in 1987, the foundation more than two and a half decades after of Fateh, its main rival in Palestinian politics. At its founding, it represented both the Palestinian wing of the Muslim Brotherhood organization, and at the same time, a generational rebellion against it. Since then, Hamas has followed its own unique trajectory, leaving its own special mark on the Palestinian national struggle. (Awad, 2021)

Political Science

The academic discipline of political science plays a crucial role in analyzing and understanding the Israeli-Palestinian conflict, offering insights into the political structures, processes, and dynamics that shape the conflict.

According to Dr. Rynhold in his article on Democrats' Attitudes toward the Israeli Palestinian Conflict stated. Starting from the first Palestinian Intifada in 1988 up to the breakdown of the Oslo process in 2000, the level of support from the American public for both Israel and the Palestinians was, significantly influenced by perceptions of their commitment to achieving peace. (29) Rynhold, 2020).

(Karakuş, 2023) stated I argue that Islamist/jihadist armed actors would be more receptive to a ceasefire if the formulation of agreements centered on humanitarian features such as the release of prisoners, the withdrawal of rebels with their families, the access to humanitarian aid, and public exchange, rather than tactical ones such as controlling strategic highways or checkpoints, power centers, the oil trade, organizing joint operations against the same enemy, etc.

(Jaspersen, & Montibeller,2020). On the learning patterns and adaptive behavior of terrorist organizations. The threat to national security posed by terrorists makes the design of evidence-based counter-terrorism strategies paramount.

(Bogaards, Helms, & Lijphart,2019) stated scholars have recommended consociationalism for their plural societies. Another good example of the popularity of consociationalism as an option for post-conflict societies is the edited volume on "Post-Conflict Power-Sharing Agreements:

Sociology

The academic discipline of sociology plays a significant role in understanding and analyzing the Israeli-Palestinian conflict from various perspectives. Sociologists contribute to the discourse by examining the social, cultural, and structural aspects of conflict.

Emotions shape the perceptions, motivations, decisions, actions, and social relationships of individuals and groups (Huntsinger et al., 2014; Lerner et al., 2003). In the context of prolonged conflicts, negative emotions are catalysts for conflict escalation and increased violence. (Gur, Ayal, & Halperin, 2021)

(Pratiwi,2022) stated in an assessment article Israeli-Palestinian Conflict Beyond Resolution: The root of the failures in the negotiation attempts to achieve peace between Israel and Palestine could be traced to the hesitation by both parties to make compromises in at least four core issues, namely borders, security, the status of Jerusalem, and the status of refugee.

(Ahmad ,2023) stated in his article on Land for Peace? The conflict in Israel-Palestine is one of the most protracted of the contemporary period, with past mediation

efforts repeatedly failing to produce a two-state solution, seen internationally as a legally just and feasible resolution.

(Cárdenas, & Sablonnière, 2020) When any of these basic needs are lower than what is potentially possible, there is violence (Galtung, 1990). violence can be structural, such as when social institutions prevent need satisfaction (e.g., systematic genocide);

Perspective from Discipline 1 (History)

Historical Analyses: Dine, T. A. (2022). Article The Limits of Détente:

Author's conclusion: Daigle argues that the October 1973 war highlighted the limitations of détente. Despite the potential for a quick end through a UN Security Council ceasefire, both superpowers opted to prolong the conflict by initiating massive weapons airlifts for their clients, thereby worsening Soviet American relations. Daigle concludes that the war was a result of Soviet American decision-making during the preceding four and a half years, reflecting the consequences of détente. However, Sadat's strategy proved successful, as he managed to bring the Arab Israeli crisis to the forefront of American foreign policy and initiate the process leading to the return of the Sinai Peninsula to Egyptian hands in three weeks. (Dine,2022)

Historical Analyses: Khaled, T. (2023). Article The Palestinian Nakba

Authors Conclusion, Preserving the United Nations Relief and Works Agency for Palestine Refugees in the Near East (UNRWA) is vital for upholding the national, individual, and collective rights of Palestinians. It stands as a firm national stance against attempts to undermine their just cause. Despite the belief that the older Palestinian generation would fade away, after 75 years of Nakba and struggle, the new generation is even more committed to the national cause. They steadfastly assert that the Palestinian

struggle will endure, and they will eventually achieve their rights, raising their flag in the Old City of Jerusalem on mosques and churches. “Since this enabled them to research the Nakba of the Palestinian people and what accompanied it, namely massacres, the policy of deportation, displacement and ethnic cleansing that took place in 1948.)

Perspective From Discipline 2 (Political Science)

Political Science: D. Karakus, 2023 Article Resolution of local conflicts involving armed Islamists: p.58-75

D. Karakus concludes the article reveals three key findings. Firstly, it suggests that violent Islamist actors are more likely to accept a ceasefire if the agreement prioritizes humanitarian concerns over tactical ones and if the implementation is gradual. This prioritization is linked to the impact of extended sieges, combatant fatigue, and public pressure. Slow implementation is viewed as a confidence-building measure. Secondly, contrary to previous studies, the involvement of third parties does not significantly impact achieving a ceasefire with Islamist/jihadist actors.

Further investigation is, needed to understand why mediation is ineffective with these groups and whether this trend is unique to Syria. These insights offer valuable guidance for policymakers and negotiators working towards peace in Syria. “In the 2010s, violent Islamist actors have become increasingly involved in intrastate armed conflicts, but little is known about how these conflicts can be, resolved...” (Karakus,2023)

Lastly, enhancing UN involvement in civil conflicts could be achieved through collaboration with local mediators. These local actors have the capability, expertise, and a reputable, impartial standing on the ground. However, their mediation efforts may face

obstacles if designated as terrorist groups or if the UN Security Council withholds full authorization. Future research could focus on strengthening the UN's role in expediting mediation for local ceasefire agreements, aiming to prevent and resolve prolonged civil wars. (Karakus,2023)

Perspective From Discipline 3 (Sociology)

Sociology Gur, Tamar; Ayal, Shahar; Halperin, Eran European journal of social psychology, 2021 1A bright side of sadness: The depolarizing role of sadness in intergroup conflicts.

"…. Sadness is one emotion frequently elicited by the price of such conflicts. This investigation characterized the effects of sadness on conflict..." Gur, Tamar; Ayal, Shahar; Halperin (2021)

Findings from four experimental studies suggest that both incidental and integral sadness can induce a depolarization of political attitudes. In Study 1 (N = 163), sadness reduced the effect of political ideology on conflict-related decisions. Sadness reduced the effect of political ideology on in-group bias in resource allocation in Studies 2 (N = 213) and 4 (N = 274), willingness to negotiate in Studies 1 and 3 (N = 174), and openness to information supporting the out-group's perspective (Study 4). Overall, in addition to its more negative implications, these results suggest that sadness (compared to both the non-emotional and anger conditions) may have a bright side, since it may induce depolarization of political attitudes in intractable conflicts. Gur, Tamar; Ayal, Shahar; Halperin, (2021).

Authors conclusion: Extremist ideologies and violent intergroup actions present a significant global societal challenge. Therefore, identifying potential mechanisms to mitigate polarization and promote thoughtful deliberation is of utmost importance. Our

perspective suggests that an emotion arising from entrenched violent conflicts could function as a depolarizing agent, diminishing radicalization and potentially aiding conflict resolution. This research offers insights into a possible emotional pathway for reducing polarization. However, thorough exploration of the use of sadness as a depolarizing agent, including the manipulated population, its intensity, and timing, is essential. We envision this work as a starting point for ongoing research to delineate the boundaries and potential practical applications of this effect. (Gur, Ayal, & Halperin,2021)

Perspective From Structured Interview: Sargent First Class Steven Hall (retired)

Open -end questions concerning the Israeli -Palestinian Conflict

My interview began with asking Sargent Hall about what region is at the heart of the conflict. He stated the West Bank, Gaza Strip, and Israel. My next question was what effects World War ll have on the conflict. He stated World War II had an enormous impact on Palestine, more European Jews were allowed to migrate to Palestine**.**

We discussed the Zionist movement and the leader of the PLO which was Arafat. We discussed the Intifada and how it related to the struggle. The rise of militant Islam is discussed in my research paper. I ask him about Hamas I followed up with a question of "will the local violence be contained? He was honest in his response, he said no it will always be armed conflict in the area. He did not feel that the Muslim countries would come closer together as a result of the conflict. The future of the U.S and Israeli relation would remain the same. We ended our interview with what could realistically be done to promote Israeli-Palestinian peace? He stated a two-step solution.

Integrative Approach

Contextualization is a method employed to situate the subject of investigation within a specific time limit, cultural environment, and personal context. This is an appropriate approach to take as it encompasses the history, political issues as well as the societal problems concerning the Israeli-Palestinian conflict.

The Israeli-Palestinian conflict is a complex and long-standing dispute over territorial claims and national identity in the Middle East. Originating from historical, religious, and political factors, the conflict centers on competing assertions to the same land, particularly Jerusalem.

The establishment of Israel in 1948 and subsequent wars have fueled ongoing tensions, involving issues such as Palestinian statehood, refugee status, and control over Jerusalem. Despite international efforts for peace, achieving a lasting resolution remains challenging due to geopolitical complexities and differing narratives. The conflict profoundly impacts both Israelis and Palestinians, with its resolution requiring a nuanced and sensitive approach.

Understanding history involves various approaches to provide context and meaning to past events. One way is through a socio-cultural lens, examining how societal norms, beliefs, and values shaped historical developments. Additionally, a political perspective delves into the power dynamics, governance structures, and key political figures influencing historical outcomes. Exploring these interdisciplinary connections can provide a comprehensive understanding of the complex tapestry of human history.

Conclusion

In summary, looking at the Israeli-Palestinian conflict through the lenses of history, politics, and sociology reveals its complexity. By understanding the historical roots, political dynamics, and societal aspects, we gain a more complete picture. Resolving this issue requires addressing not just political issues but also historical and social factors. Bringing these perspectives together is crucial for working towards a lasting and fair solution in the region. The interdisciplinary approach illuminates the nature of this enduring struggle.

Lessons Learned

I learned that there are parallels between the current situations in the Middle East and historical colonialism. It is some fundamental differences between the involved parties that make common ground difficult to find. We have two parties that feel a historic God given right to the territory. One party is backed up by Western Superpowers and the opposing party is backup by several Middle Eastern entities. This makes both parties effectively proxies adding to the myriad complexities of the conflict.

Recommendation

I recommend a three -state solution where the opposing party recognizes Israel right to exist. The formation of a Palestinian State with all the rights, privileges, and responsibilities of a Modern State. With Jerusalem as an independent City State a coalition government run by both Israeli's and Palestinians supported by the U.N.

Reflection on Research

I found it challenging in the beginning but once I learned how to research articles it became interesting, and I am sure I will use this again in my work. I am thankful to the library staff who taught me how to use the system.

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